

Chapter 151_2 - Demonic Aura

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Chu Qingqiu still did not wait for Ning Fuyi that night. Soon the horizon brightened, and piercing flute sounds tore through the deep blue sky above Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. The sky's color gradually brightened with the rising sun, finally fading to a clear blue.

The disciples rose at dawn to the flute sounds, preparing their gear with excitement, and all proceeded to Cloud Deep Hall. Thousands of disciples arranged themselves in neat rows, their four-colored sect robes spread out in blocks, creating an impressive sight when viewed from above.

Feng Ge and Hong Ying held name registers, going through each courtyard's disciple formations to check them one by one. Any disciples not on the roster were brought out and left to guard Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate.

Most of the North Courtyard disciples were left behind to guard the mountain. A few disobedient ones tried to sneak into the formation but were mercilessly grabbed by the neck and pulled aside by Hong Ying.

"Senior Brother, I just broke through to Rising Realm and got a handy magical weapon. Please be flexible and let me go!" Xiang Yushan hugged Hong Ying's leg, clinging persistently.

Hong Ying frowned and shook his leg, lifting his robe: "Nonsense! Do you know how dangerous this mission is? Even I might not survive, and with your meager cultivation, you'd just be throwing your life away."

He pushed him away with his sword hilt and ignored his continued pestering.

From the other side, Feng Ge similarly pulled out several low-cultivation disciples and threw them aside. When she reached the South Courtyard front, she smiled at Liu Wenzhu and Hua Feihua who were leading.

"Wenzhu, you're the outstanding one among South Courtyard disciples. Remember to lead them in clearing out immortal soldiers from the rear. Don't try to stand out too much to avoid casualties."

"I understand, Senior Sister," Liu Wenzhu nodded.

"Hua Feihua..."

"I will be in the front lines," Hua Feihua said. "After all, I need to control puppets, so I should do my part for Feihua Sect."

"Thank you." After Feng Ge finished speaking, she looked at the fresh and handsome Hua Feihua, then at the gentle and graceful Liu Wenzhu beside her, and couldn't help smiling.

Seeing her expression, Liu Wenzhu knew what she was thinking. Feeling embarrassed, she quickly pushed her away: "Senior Sister, it's getting late."

She didn't control her strength and nearly pushed Feng Ge off Cloud Ascension Mountain. Fortunately, Feng Ge had deep cultivation and steadied herself, clutching the name register with lingering fear: "Alright, alright."

She suddenly remembered something and put her lips to Liu Wenzhu's ear, whispering: "Also remember to remind Rong Jin more. He doesn't have much immortal power now, so he should just stay in the rear and await orders. Don't let him rush forward."

"I'm afraid he might overthink if I mention it. Since you've been close since childhood, it's more convenient for you to speak," Feng Ge sighed.

"Yes, Senior Sister," Liu Wenzhu responded quietly.

Soon the headcount was complete. Dozens of Flying Eagle boats were already waiting below the cliff. The disciples stopped joking around and boarded the ships in formation. Chu Qingqiu stood at the front on Bai Lin's back, with Elder Pingyao and Elder Jingshan standing beside her.

Even the First Elder, whose eyes could barely open, was among them, currently leaning against a sandalwood chair, sleeping with weak breathing.

"Didn't I say the First Elder didn't need to come?" Chu Qingqiu said. "He's old, and this situation will certainly be dangerous."

"I couldn't persuade him," Elder Pingyao shook her head. She looked up and saw Chu Qingqiu's grave expression, then asked, "Is the Divine Venerable worried?"

Chu Qingqiu didn't answer but handed her a letter. Elder Pingyao opened it and was immediately shocked.

"Why would there be an earthquake for no reason?" Her hand holding the letter was trembling.

"Last night I noticed something unusual when observing the stars. At moonset I indeed received Sect Leader Tang's message saying there was an earthquake in the Central Plains. Qi Kingdom and surrounding small countries suffered countless casualties," Chu Qingqiu said.

"This is too strange. It must be related to Penglai, but what kind of power can move heaven and earth? Even gods would find it difficult," Elder Pingyao's face turned iron-blue with anger as she crumpled the letter.

"Divine Venerable, it seems this journey will be extremely difficult," she sighed.

Chu Qingqiu's fingertip traced over the end of the white bone, her eyelashes trembling slightly.

Zhaoyao Mountain had long been occupied by disciples from other sects. The Zhaoyao Saint had specially opened the cloud sea for this, creating a huge area above Zhaoyao Mountain. When Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate arrived, the cloud sea was already bustling with people.

Even previous gatherings had never seen so many immortal sect members. Now it seemed like everyone from the entire immortal realm was here. In the middle, the blue and white robes were clearly distinguished. Whether male or female, all had their hair bound and stood with dignity—this was clearly Tianxuan Sword Sect.

The eastern area with its chattering women needed no description. Just standing there brought gentle fragrant breezes that drifted with the clouds into everyone's ears and noses, making several disciples with unstable dao hearts blush. Fortunately, Tang Wenshu waved to send wind to blow away the fragrance, preventing any incidents.

To the west stood Kongming Sect and Guijian Sect, both with vast numbers. Guijian Sect members wore black robes and stood silently, while neighboring Kongming Sect's area was filled with brilliant light, with sunlight reflecting off those bald heads in a somewhat dazzling manner.

Rolling white smoke flowed past their feet. Chu Qingqiu rode Bai Lin up from the cloud sea, immediately drawing everyone's attention. She lowered her eyes without looking much and walked slowly into the cloud sea.

She passed by Jiang Li's side and nodded to her.

"The Divine Venerable has arrived," Tang Wenshu quickly stepped forward to greet her quietly. His eyes swept behind Chu Qingqiu but didn't see that black-robed figure, so he asked, "Ning Fuyi isn't here?"

"She has urgent business and hasn't returned yet," Chu Qingqiu answered.

Tang Wenshu waved over several sect leaders. When everyone gathered together, he spoke: "You should all know about last night's earthquake in the Central Plains?"

"We received letters before departure and already knew," Li Hanhan's originally rosy complexion was somewhat pale. She lowered her head, fidgeting with her long whip. "It seems Penglai has other tricks besides the Wuji ghost fire."

"What's there to fear!" Guijian Sect's leader scoffed. "We immortal sects have tens of thousands of disciples. I don't believe we can't destroy one immortal mountain!"

"We can't be careless," Chu Qingqiu said calmly. "Since Penglai dares to provoke like this, they must have thought of countermeasures or are confident they can defeat us."

"If they weren't pressing us step by step, our immortal sects wouldn't need to be so passive," she continued.

Guijian Sect's leader touched his mouth: "But now besides destroying Penglai, there's no other way. Since Penglai can cause earthquakes in the Central Plains, they can certainly control other things."

"If we don't stop them in time, I'm afraid these six realms will truly cease to exist," he sighed.

"Exactly so," Tang Wenshu said. "Therefore we absolutely cannot be careless. We must protect this land beneath our feet and not let all living beings be destroyed by villains."

Everyone nodded in agreement.

After the immortal sects gathered, they set off for Penglai. As the immortals passed overhead, mortals looking up saw rolling clouds and mist, magnificent as a cloud sea.

Within half a day, the pure white clouds ahead gained color. At first, only faint red and yellow could be seen, but as they drew closer, they saw colored ribbons streaking across the sky.

Below the ribbons, emerald stones gleamed brilliantly. Thousand-zhang waterfalls cascaded from the sky with rushing sounds, water vapor splashing and forming dazzling rainbows in the sunlight—thus they knew they had reached Penglai Immortal Mountain.

Chu Qingqiu stood at the very front. Faint water drops fell on her shoes, then quickly dried in the wind.

"Who comes here?" A resonant voice rang out from within the water curtain, echoing through the high sky. A transparent head as large as the immortal mountain itself rose from the water vapor, eyes lowered, looking down upon all the immortals.

This sight was extremely oppressive. Many disciples looked up in shock, holding their breath.

"I am Chu Qingqiu," Chu Qingqiu said, as if she hadn't seen that head at all, speaking indifferently to the waterfall before her.

The head let out a contemptuous laugh, then faded away, replaced by a man wearing dragon-patterned robes. His face was gaunt, but his mouth was purplish-red. He wore fire-flow boots and a crown inlaid with pearls—altogether a magnificent appearance.

"Is this the legendary Emperor Tianrui?" someone whispered from behind, but as soon as the words fell, the man suddenly appeared before Chu Qingqiu, startling all the disciples into crying out and drawing their weapons.

That man had appeared without even a ripple of air currents—his cultivation was clearly extraordinary.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling," the man stared at Chu Qingqiu with a smile, suddenly extending his hand toward her.

"Don't touch her!" Li Hanhan beside them angrily lashed out with her long whip, but before it could reach the man, it suddenly turned into scattered flower petals. Li Hanhan was immediately stunned.

The man remained motionless, looking at Li Hanhan like examining an ant, then continued smiling as he reached toward Chu Qingqiu, whose aura was growing increasingly cold.

But this movement quickly stopped, because a thick trident flew from somewhere unknown, severing the man's arm which fell to the ground and turned into a puddle of water.

Everyone including the man looked up, and Tang Wenshu at the rear called out in shock: "Such strong demonic aura!"